CANNABIS

Also known as WEED, MARIJUANA, HASH or SKUNK

KNOW THE RISKS

Cannabis can affect memory, mood, mental health and reaction time.

Effects vary by person, THC strength, frequency of use and age.

WHAT IS CANNABIS?

Cannabis is a drug made from the cannabis plant. THC is the main ingredient responsible for the high. It may be smoked, vaped or eaten in edible products. Stronger forms can produce more intense and unpredictable effects.

SHORT-TERM EFFECTS

Relaxation or altered perception, but also anxiety, panic, confusion, impaired memory, slower reactions and reduced coordination. Some people experience paranoia.

DRIVING & ACCIDENTS

Cannabis can affect attention, reaction time, judgement and coordination. Never drive, cycle in traffic or operate machinery while affected.

DEPENDENCE & WITHDRAWAL

Regular use can lead to dependence. When stopping, some people experience irritability, sleep problems, low mood, restlessness and cravings.

MENTAL HEALTH RISKS

Cannabis can trigger severe anxiety and, for some people, paranoia or psychotic symptoms. Frequent use and high-THC products are linked to a greater risk, particularly in vulnerable people.

IMPORTANT WARNING SIGNS

Severe paranoia, hearing or seeing things others do not, unusual beliefs, confusion, or major changes in behaviour should not be dismissed as simply being high. Seek prompt professional assessment.

THE KEY MESSAGE

Being common does not make cannabis risk-free. Speak early, without judgement.

RECOGNISE THE SIGNS. GET HELP EARLY.

Practical information for individuals, parents and families.

WHEN TO SEEK HELP

If someone becomes frightened, confused, severely paranoid, hears voices or appears detached from reality, arrange prompt medical assessment. If there is immediate danger, severe agitation or risk of harm, call 999. Do not leave an unsafe person alone.

WHAT YOU CAN DO

Avoid driving while affected. If cannabis is affecting your sleep, mood, work or relationships, speak with a GP or drug support service. Parents and carers: ask calm questions, listen first, and avoid threats or shaming.

UK LAW | ENGLAND & WALES

Cannabis is a Class B controlled drug. The penalties below are maximums unless stated otherwise.

POSSESSION	Up to 5 years in prison, an unlimited fine, or both.
SELLING / SUPPLY	Up to 14 years in prison, an unlimited fine, or both.
DRUG-DRIVING	Minimum 1-year driving ban; up to 6 months in prison, an unlimited fine and a criminal record.

Police may issue a warning or fixed penalty for some possession cases. Most recreational cannabis remains illegal; lawful prescribed cannabis is subject to separate rules.

FAMILIES, STIGMA & SUPPORT

Fear of judgement can delay people asking for help. Cannabis-related mental health symptoms need assessment, not blame. A calm conversation and an offer to accompany someone to an appointment can make a real difference.

LOCAL SUPPORT IN ROCHDALE

TURNING POINT / ROAR

Adults: drug and alcohol recovery support | 0300 555 0234

EARLY BREAK

Young people and families | 0161 723 3880

Seeking help is a sign of strength, not shame.

Sources: NHS; GOV.UK drug penalties & drug-driving law; THINK! | Reviewed Nov 2026